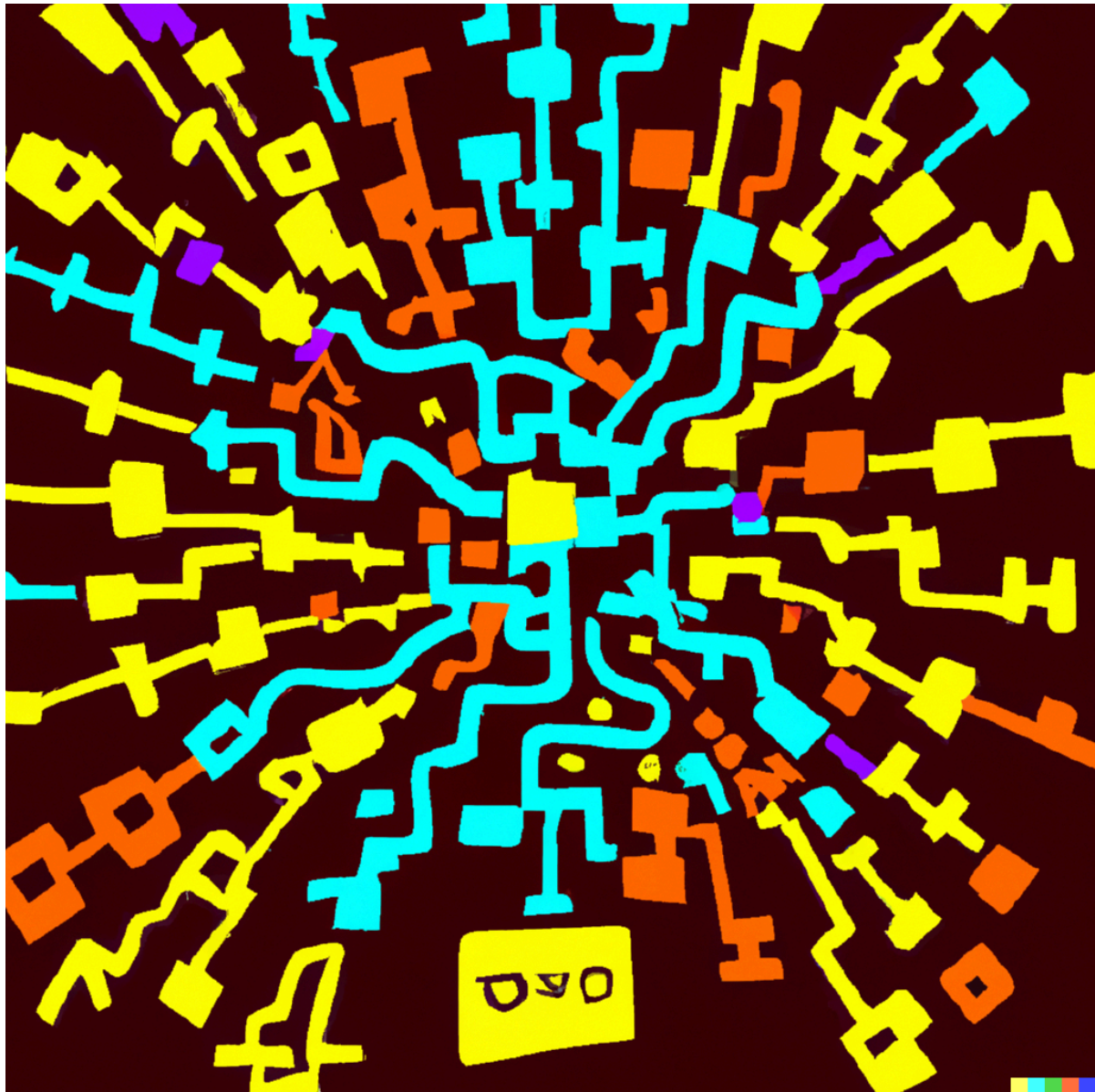


How to unf*ck your org

Organisational Strategy and Architecture for Badasses

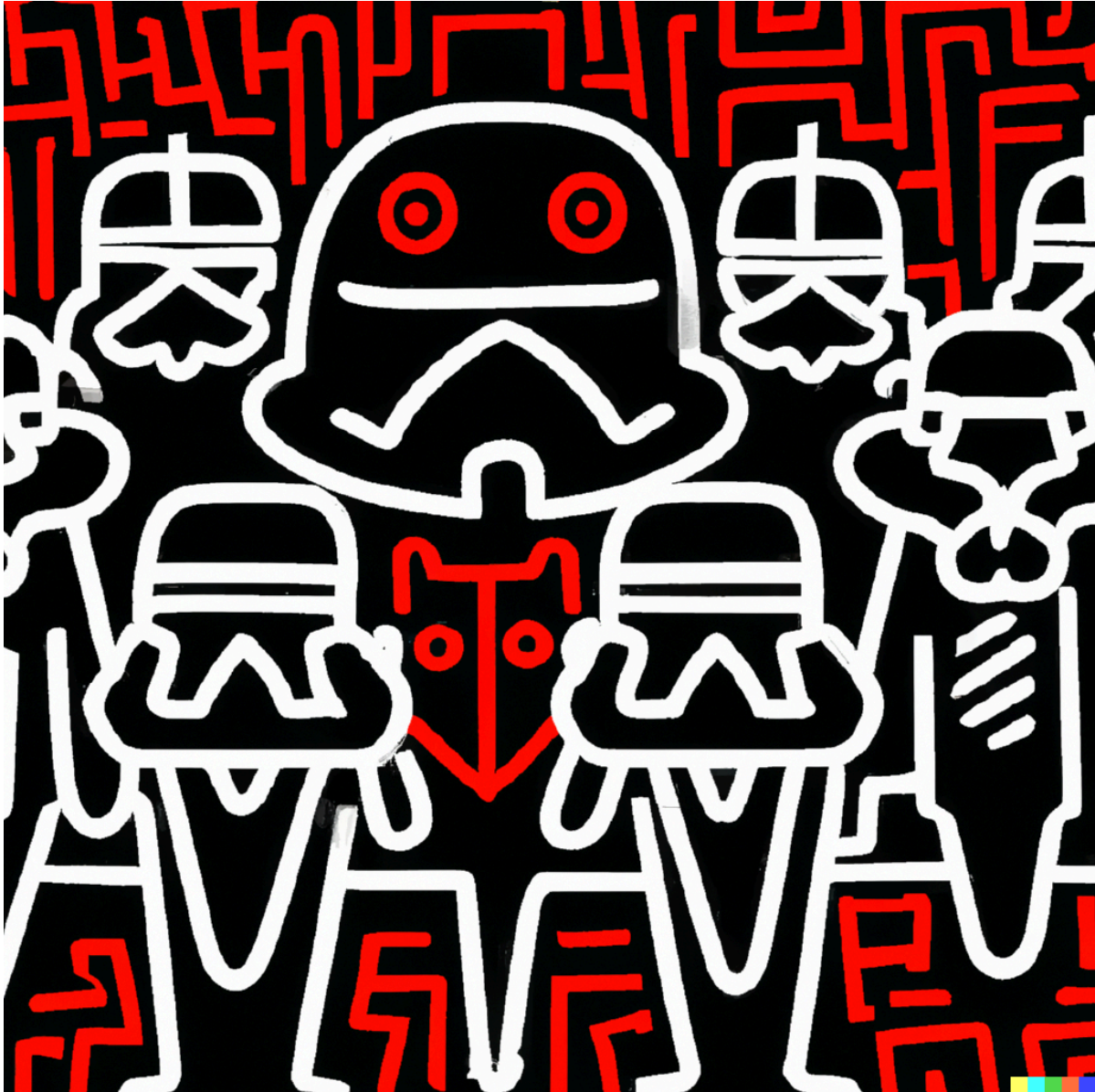
"If you want to build a ship, don't herd people together to collect wood and don't assign them tasks and work, but rather teach them to long for the endless immensity of the sea." (Antoine de Saint-Exupery)



Meta

- Is this an email course? A self-serve one? A cohort-based thing?
 - Could start with a 7-email course to test the waters:
 - i. Introduction (reasons you might want to unf*ck your org) VALUE.
 - ii. Grokking your context
 - iii. Developing a mental model (psychological safety, openness, governance)
 - iv. Prioritising all the things (Strategy)
 - v. Spotting potential problems
 - vi. Working transparently and iteratively
 - vii. Rubber hits the road (conclusion)
- Are there activities to do, or is it designed to provoke people's thinking?
 - Could create a forum for people doing the course to get feedback / interact with one another. Could even just be an #unfckyourorg channel on our Slack?
- Do we need a diagnostic tool to see if this course is for someone interested?
 - e.g. "on a scale of 1-5 how confident are you that there is a process that is defined and followed for core functions in your organisation?"
- What kind of metaphor could we use for this course:
 - Journey up a mountain (too obvious?)
 - Car journey to go on holiday (could we do something which is a bit 'greener'?)
 - Stepping stones? From land of fucked to unfucked
 - Sailboat journey (like Tethix, could be useful in terms of changing course based on the prevailing wind, PIRATES!)
 - Journey to the moon ('moonshoot' is a bit cliched)
 - Untangling a ball of wool/string
 - Skydive
 - Rebel Alliance destroying the Death Star
 - Film metaphors...

0. Intro



Hi and welcome [Name],

This “How unfu*ck your org” course is made to help forward-thinking people who might need some help and orientation to create change within their organisation. Maybe you are tired of reading clickbait articles from outlets such as Forbes and Business Insider that promise a lot and deliver very little. Or perhaps you’re just not sure where to start and where to turn for tools and resources that actually work.

Could it be that you’re getting ready to start your own Rebel Alliance? Are you eager to improve the culture, efficiency or impact of your organisation? ✨

We at WAO work with complex, multinational clients as well as smaller groups containing just a handful of people. While every organisation is different, we've noticed things in common that we often help them untangle.

People often come to us wanting some kind of three or five year plan for their organisation. There's nothing wrong with planning but what's more helpful, we find, is to help them with a clear-eyed view of *where they're currently at*. After all, if you don't know where you're starting from (your context), it's going to be very difficult to chart a course to your destination!

This course offers you a generalised introduction to the things we've noticed and solved with other orgs. It uses the tools and approaches that we use when working with clients, and these resources are openly-licensed and free for you to use as you see fit. We highly recommend that you use these tools in collaboration with other people in your organisation. More brains are always better (which is why octopuses have nine)!

We're always looking to improve this course, so if you've got some suggestions for it, then we're all ears! Also, if you want to know more about WAO or want to develop custom solutions for your organisation, talk to us. In both cases, just hit reply and your email will wing its way to us!

Could your organisation do with more in-depth assistance or some workshops on this stuff? We Are Open runs tailored programmes with organisations of every size. [Get in touch](#) to find out more!



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- Who this course is for
 - Forward-thinking senior people new to their job
 - People who feel like reading Forbes is kinda bullshit
 - Those who aren't sure where to turn for things that actually work quickly

- What to expect from this course
 - Introductory and generalised course
 - If you want it more specific for your Org talk to WAO
 -
- Why we put it together
 - To improve organisational culture (people)
 - To improve organisational efficiency (products)
 - To improve organisational impact (processes)
- If you use the tools offered have people, product & process in the back of your head
 - Who are you thinking about while using the tool
- <https://opencollective.com/weareopen>

1. Grokking your context



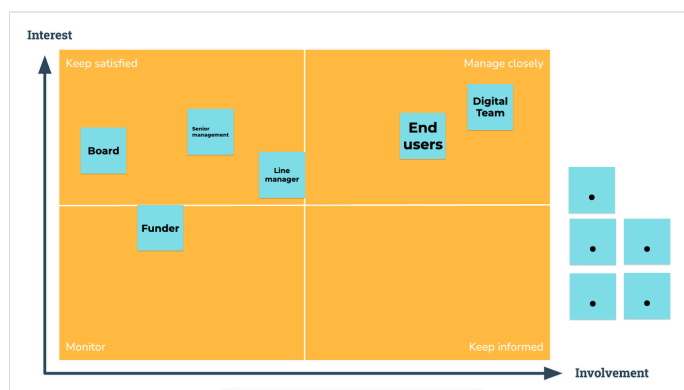
Whatever you're trying to change in your organisation, whether it be a change to improve the internal culture, improve efficiency or create greater external impact, you'll want to start by having a proper think about your *context*.

Your context is everything from your role in the organisation, to your organisation's role in your sector, through to your sector's role in the bigger picture of the world. Generalising how to think about context is a tricky thing to do because it is, ahem, contextual.

The first thing you should do is think about why your organisation exists. One of our clients, Greenpeace, has a mission which includes: *“Our goal is to ensure the ability of the earth to nurture life in all its diversity.”* This helps them stay on course. You might work for a for-profit company that’s looking to maximise shareholder value or make enough money for the founders to buy an island. It’s likely that your organisation is somewhere in between nurturing life and making money.

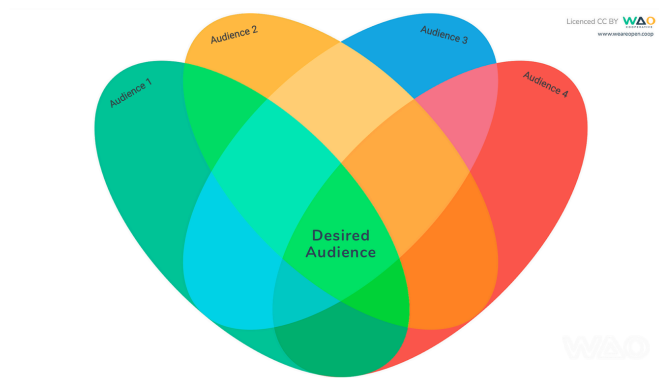
Whatever your organisation’s “mission statement” it’s worth having it in mind as you begin to think about the people involved. Otherwise, you can end up with a skewed vision of which direction it’s appropriate to be heading in. Strategy, after all, is mostly about course-correction.

Here are three tools that can help:



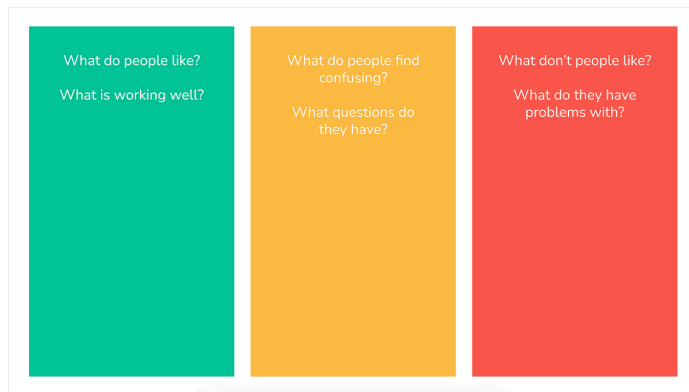
Stakeholder mapping

As you get started, you and your team should sit down and discuss who will be impacted by your work. You’ll want to map the interest and involvement of each of your stakeholders. A stakeholder is anyone who has an interest in your success.



Audience ikigai

Whether you're building or delivering products or services, you will have an audience who will be impacted by the work that you do. These people are a subset of your stakeholders - who are they? How can you meet their needs?



Traffic light categorisation

Now that you know who your stakeholders and audience are, it's time to focus on serving their needs. You need to talk with them, doing some user research, rather than just pretending you know what it is that they want. This tool is a super-simple way of categorising what you discover into things people like, things they find confusing, and things they don't like.

As we said above, everyone's context is different, which means that it's worth doing all of these activities with your colleagues, stakeholders, and members of your audience. This is why diversity of thinking is so important: it helps us identify blind spots and assumptions that we're making. We can then do something about that.

Next time, we're going to talk about developing a mental model of your organisation. This can be used to help stakeholders, including your staff and audience, have a picture in their head of what it is you stand for - and the journey you're trying to take them on.

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2. Developing a mental model



Last time around, we discussed the importance of understanding the context of your organisation and the people it impacts. If you're not sure why it exists, who your stakeholders are, and/or what's working, then it's going to be difficult to generate a plan

for a way forward. If you haven't gone through the activities linked to in the last email, go back and take a look!

If you've ever received some management coaching as part of your job, then your coach might have talked to you about the importance of visualisation. Helping people within your team or organisation be able to imagine themselves as going on a journey can help them understand where they're at and where they're heading.

Some examples:



Mountain - a journey to the summit (or perhaps a series of summits?)



Sailboat - a journey to a distant land, buffeted by the winds of circumstance



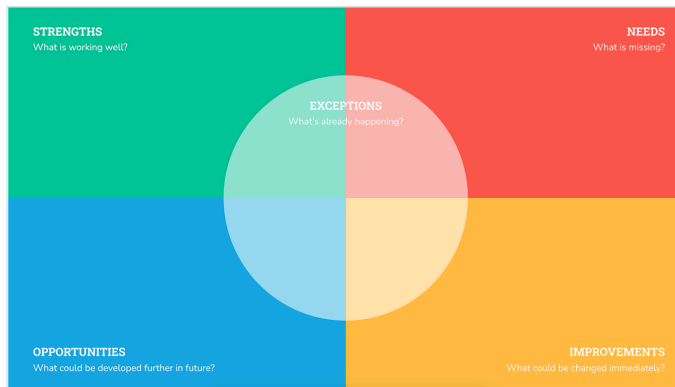
Rebel Alliance - a heroic attempt to destroy the Death Star

Whatever it is, choose something that makes sense for you *and* resonates with the people you're talking with. Just please don't choose a pirate ship. So cliché!

The way that we conceptualise the work we're doing is important. As Gareth Morgan talks about in his seminal book [*Images of Organization*](#), there's a big difference between seeing your org as a 'machine' vs an 'organism'. The language you use when talking about initiatives and strategy has a real-world impact.

In our work with clients, we like to look at all of the documentation they've created to date around strategies and initiatives. Starting from a blank slate is sometimes part of the problem for orgs as it deprecates the important business of knowledge management. So have a look at existing strategy docs you have, as well as meeting notes, Slack chats, and anywhere else people have talked about the future of your organisation.

Here are three tools that can help:



NOISE model

When you look at your strategy docs, chats, and other materials, what do you notice in terms of Needs, Opportunities, Improvements, Strengths, and Exceptions? This resource helps you start to identify the areas that you might need to work on first.



Strategic Starfish

Sometimes it's worth asking really simple questions of yourself and the people you work with. This could be the leadership team, your board, a group of influential stakeholders, or just whoever you think is relevant. Facilitate a session just asking questions like "what should we be doing more of?" and "what should we stop doing?"



[Why working openly on ambitious projects breeds excitement](#)

This post on the WAO blog explains why it's important to be ambitious with your organisational strategy work - and to be as open as you can be. Doing so leads to people being excited about it, which is motivational!

As we said last time, everyone's context is different, which means that it's worth doing all of these activities with your colleagues, stakeholders, and members of your audience. Diversity of thinking is important as it helps us identify blind spots and assumptions that we're making. We can then do something about that!

Next time, we're going to talk about *prioritisation*. Now that you've got a clearer picture of your context and have developed a mental model of your organisation, it's time to think about which things might be more important to achieving your mission than others.

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3. Prioritising all the things



Last time around, we discussed the importance of developing a mental model for your organisation and providing a visual metaphor. If you haven't gone through the activities linked to in the last email, go back and take a look!

As you collect insights and bits of knowledge both from your colleagues and pre-existing documentation, you're going to find some conflicting information. Different people will have varying perspectives on what problems are the most important to solve. As we collaborate with others, we'll often find that we are (slightly) at odds with one another. That's OK! Frankly, it's good if there's a little productive conflict that you need to manage. Conflict represents an opportunity for learning and growth.

If you've run the activities from previous emails, you have a collection of information that represents needs, opportunities and challenges. The next step is to begin prioritising this information in a way that can help you, your stakeholders and the wider organisation see ways to move forward. Remember, we're trying to unf*ck your organisation by improving the culture, efficiency and impact. In order to do any of those things, we need to see what kind of changes are going to resonate within your individual context.

Here are three tools that can help:

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B2	fx	I can see what I am writing, but nobody else can!											
	A	B	C	D	E	F	G						
1		Prompt 1	Prompt 2	Prompt 3	Prompt 4	Prompt 5							
2													
3	Person 1												
4	Person 2												
5	Person 3												
6	Person 4												
7	Person 5												
8													
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[Big Reveal](#)

The Big Reveal is a great way to see what people think about certain ideas or proposals. Giving people a way to respond to prompts privately allows them to focus on their formulation. Then you can discuss each person's feedback and start to find alignment amongst the team.



Must, Should, Could

Sometimes it's worth asking really simple questions of yourself and the people you work with. This could be the leadership team, your board, a group of influential stakeholders, or just whoever you think is relevant. Facilitate a session just asking questions like “what should we be doing more of?” and “what should we stop doing?”



Eisenhower Matrix

Within your organisational context there are things that need to happen *pronto*. There are also things that are important but can simmer quietly on a back burner until the timing is right. The Eisenhower Matrix plots “urgency” against “importance” and helps you figure out where to start.

Sorting through a bunch of different insights and information can be mind boggling work. Using simple tools that allow you to find priorities might take some time, but it's essential to coming up with ways forward. You should be able to see what's important

to your stakeholders and where to start. At this point, you should be ready to lay out a strategy and plan for creating the change you want to see.

In our next email, we're going to talk about *spotting potential problems*. With your very well thought out strategy and plan, you'll still need to make sure that you've not forgotten to have a think about the risks involved.

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4. Spotting potential problems



Last time around, we discussed the importance of prioritising both your work and opportunities that arise so you know what needs to be done NOW, and what is perhaps less important. If you haven't gone through the activities linked to in the last email, go back and take a look!

Proritisation without having a deep understanding of your context is an exercise in futility. It's a hope that some handwavey plans for the future bear any resemblance and relevance to where your organisation is and what it needs.

Likewise, you can only really spot problems in your plans once you've prioritised them. This is because you can only figure out potential conflicts when you know that one activity is more important than another.

This is a general introduction, so the changes that you want to make in order to unf*ck your organisation could take many different guises. For example, you may be entirely focused on making internal processes more efficient. Alternatively, you could be set on engaging and inspiring a community. Or it might be that you need to pivot your organisation to follow a different strategy entirely compared with what came before.

Whatever it is that you plan to do, removing obstacles before you come to them is always a smart thing to do. So it's important to think about *how* you're going to do things, as well as *why* and *what* you're doing. If we wanted to get all philosophical about it, we'd stroke our chins and talk about moving beyond ontology (what exists?) into the world of epistemology (what can be known?)

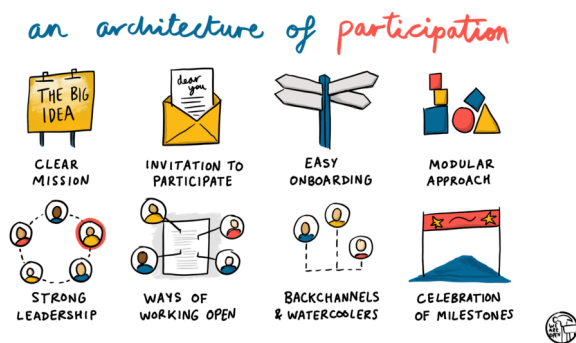
Here are three tools that can help:



Pre-mortem

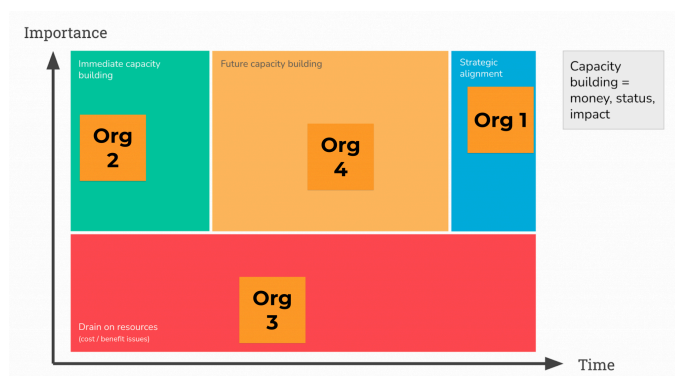
Everyone knows what a post-mortem is: when someone, or something, dies you figure out the cause of death. In the world of business, a post-mortem is run when a project or programme fails. A *pre-mortem* is about *imagining* that it's X number of months down the line, and the project you're about to embark on has failed wildly. Why is that? You list all the reasons, which could be internal or external, and then figure out ways to stop them happening, as well as ways to lessen their impact.

(note: this technique is so revelatory that we'd argue that if you only do **one** activity with your colleagues, do this one!)



Architecture of Participation

There are many different kinds of communities. Some are geographically-based, some are professional within a single organisation, some are between orgs. Others are entirely different. What they have in common is *participation*, and this approach allows you to go through eight ways in which you can improve the participation (and therefore engagement) of your community.



Opportunity Prioritisation

Don't let the word 'prioritisation' put you off here; this activity is about removing blockers in terms of your work with other organisations. There will always be opportunities that present themselves to partner with people who seem to be heading in the same direction as you. But which ones are a waste of time? How can we build capacity without spinning our wheels?

We're nearly done! In our next email, we're going to put it all together and show you how to run a retrospective.

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5. Rubber hits the road

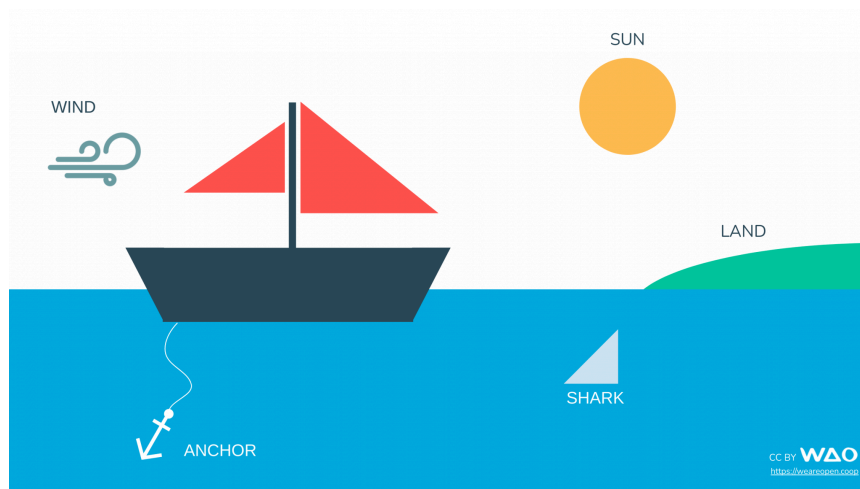


Last time around, we discussed the importance of spotting potential issues, roadblocks, and risks with your work. This is so you can prevent them from happening, or mitigating their impact if they're already causing problems. If you haven't gone through the activities linked to in the last email, go back and take a look!

Hey, congratulations! You've been exposed to a lot of information and insight over the past few emails.

Our aim in creating this course was that you'd find the advice and activities useful and actionable. Hopefully, they will provide a starting point for you to start to unf*ck your organisation! As with anything you learn, or a project you lead, it's always worth reflecting on your experiences.

For this, we have one more tool to share with you:



Sailboat Retrospective

This extremely simple diagram can be a very useful tool for thinking about the things that went well, and didn't go so well with whatever it is you're thinking back upon. While it's something that can be filled in by an individual (why not do one for this course?) it comes into its own when used by a group or team. The insights you gain based on the conversation it engenders, can be eye-opening!

With that, **you're ready to be the change you want to see in your organisation.** If you've made it this far, we offer our sincere congratulations! This kind of strategic, world-changing work is *hard*. We would like to recognise you for what you've accomplished, so please do claim your 'Org Unf*cker' badge by replying to this email and saying GIVE ME MY BADGE!



Finally, if this course has been useful to you, please consider a donation to keep it freely available to your colleagues and people in other organisations!

DONATE TO OUR COLLECTIVE



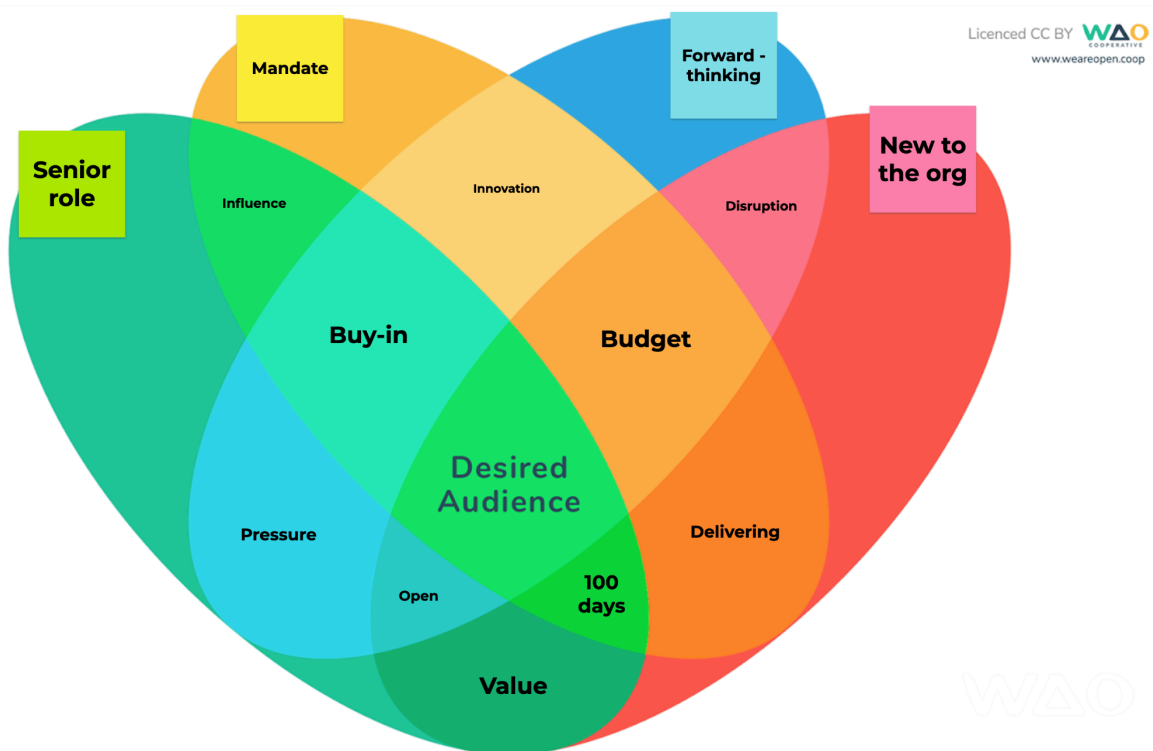
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People

- Roles
- Scope/mission
 - [Audience Ikigai](#)



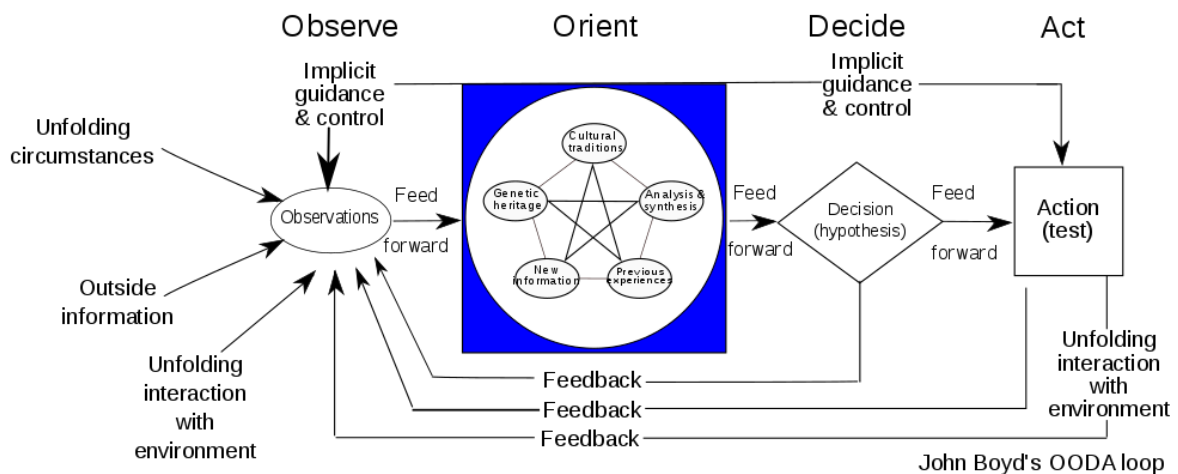
- the 5 W's of your Communications Strategy:
<https://blog.weareopen.coop/educate-engage-activate-6c6325e962d2>
- Interests/talents

Products

- Tools which enable your mission
- System ecosystem
- Linking tools together

Processes

- How decisions are made
 - [Consent-based and other forms of decision making](#)
- Change management
 - [Nonviolent communication](#)
- OODA loop
 - <https://thedecisionlab.com/reference-guide/computer-science/the-ooda-loop>



([Wikipedia](#))